Declaration of Independence

In Congress, July 4, 1776 · Thomas Jefferson, principal author

Source: Declaration of Independence (1776), text via the U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/founding-docs. Public domain.

Adopted by the Second Continental Congress on July 4, 1776, the Declaration announced the thirteen colonies' break from Great Britain. It draws on Enlightenment political philosophy — especially John Locke's natural-rights theory — to justify revolution. The document is organized in three movements: a philosophical preamble, a long list of grievances against King George III, and a formal declaration of independence.

Connect: Locke's natural-rights theory shaped Jefferson's language. What Locke phrases appear almost word-for-word in the Preamble?

Key Passages

Natural rights and the right of revolution

> We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness. … That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, … But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, … it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government,

Sample grievances

> He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good. … He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures. … For Quartering large bodies of armed troops among us: … For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world: For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent: For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury:

The declaration itself

> We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, … solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, … And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	After Lexington and Concord (1775), the failed Olive Branch Petition, and the spread of Paine's Common Sense, the Second Continental Congress voted for independence.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	King George III and Parliament, the colonists (to win support for independence), and foreign powers such as France whose help the colonies needed.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Thomas Jefferson, a Virginia planter and enslaver drafting for Congress, using Enlightenment ideas from Locke; enslaved people, women, and Native peoples are left out of 'all men.'
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Write one paragraph placing the Declaration in the broader Enlightenment / colonial-resistance context (1763–1776).
2. Identify TWO grievances and explain how each connects to a specific British policy after 1763.
3. How does Jefferson’s phrase ‘all men are created equal’ square — or fail to square — with the practice of slavery in 1776?

The Declaration of Independence

Thomas Jefferson & the Continental Congress · July 4, 1776

Source: Declaration of Independence (1776), text via the U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/founding-docs. Public domain. Non-contiguous passages are separated by [. . .]; shorter cuts inside a passage are marked with an ellipsis (. . .).

> The colonies' announcement of separation from Britain, grounding independence in natural rights and government by consent, followed by a long list of grievances against King George III.

Preamble

In Congress, July 4, 1776 The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America, When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature’s God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.—That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, —That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness. Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security.—Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies; and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former Systems of Government. The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.

Grievances against the King

He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good. . . . He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people. . . . He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures. . . . He has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitution, and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his Assent to their Acts of pretended Legislation: For Quartering large bodies of armed troops among us: For protecting them, by a mock Trial, from punishment for any Murders which they should commit on the Inhabitants of these States: For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world: For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent: For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury: For transporting us beyond Seas to be tried for pretended offences: . . . He has abdicated Government here, by declaring us out of his Protection and waging War against us. He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns, and destroyed the lives of our people. . . . He has excited domestic insurrections amongst us, and has endeavoured to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers, the merciless Indian Savages, whose known rule of warfare, is an undistinguished destruction of all ages, sexes and conditions.

In every stage of these Oppressions We have Petitioned for Redress in the most humble terms: Our repeated Petitions have been answered only by repeated injury. A Prince, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.

[. . .]

The declaration itself

We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

Words to know

unalienable — cannot be taken away or given up

Prudence — careful good judgment

transient — temporary; passing

usurpations — illegal seizures of power that belong to others

Despotism — rule by a single absolute power with no limits

Redress — correction of a wrong; relief from a grievance